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MINI PLENARY - NATIONAL ASSEMBLY  
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VOTE NO 19 - SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT

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***PROCEEDINGS OF MINI PLENARY SESSION OF THE NATIONAL ASSEMBLY***

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Members of the mini plenary session met at Good Hope Chamber at 14:00.

The House Chairperson, Mr W Horn, took the Chair and requested members to observe a moment of silence for prayer or meditation.

**APPROPRIATION BILL**

Debate on Vote No 19 - Social Development:

The ACTING MINISTER OF SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT (Ms L S Chikunga):  
House Chairperson, Chairperson, hon Bridget Masango and members of the Portfolio Committee on Social Development, Deputy Minister of the Department of Social Development, DSD, Mr Ganief Hendricks, distinguished guests and fellow South Africans. Hon Chair, it is with profound gratitude and a great

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sense of duty that I stand before this august House as the Acting Minister to table Budget Vote 19 of the DSD for the 2026-27 financial year.

From the outset, I wish to state that I fully recognise the immense responsibility that comes with this role, which I pledge to carry with utmost diligence and integrity. I am deeply honoured by the trust bestowed upon me by His Excellency the President, Mr Cyril Ramaphosa, and I pledge to work with all hon members to deliver on this portfolio's mandate.

Hon members, the year 2026 is of historic significance. It has been 70 years - a platinum jubilee - since South African women gallantly took the fight against patriarchy and apartheid's apparatus of exploitation to the Union Buildings. The year 2026 also marks 50 years - a golden jubilee - since young people fought and defeated servitude training under Bantu education disguised as an education system. We are also marking three decades since the ushering in of our Constitution as the supreme law of the land.

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It is the generations of 1956, 1976 and the lawmakers of 1996, of course, standing on our rich heritage of struggle resistance, who paved the way for women to make up 43,5% of this Parliament, an increase from a 28% representation in 1994, and 43% of the executive, up from only three women in 1994. They made it possible for 45% of our 253 judges to be women judges, up from only two women in 1994. They gave us the very first woman to occupy the position of Chief Justice and head of the apex court.

We tabled Budget Vote 19 on the 20th anniversary of the SA Social Security Agency, Sassa, under the theme, "Strengthening social protection and celebrating 20 years of Sassa: Delivering dignity, enabling the future". We pay special tribute to the late former Minister, Dr Zola Skweyiya, for his foresight and contribution to this milestone.

For two decades, Sassa has been at the centre of our resolve to shield millions from extreme poverty, restore livelihoods and facilitate pathways out of the cycle of poverty. In their 2023 research report titled, *Social Grants, Livelihoods and Poverty Responses of Social Grant Beneficiaries in South Africa*, Professor Leila Patel of the University of

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Johannesburg and her colleagues found that our grants have enabled beneficiaries to pursue diverse livelihoods consisting of both formal and informal work, to start and sustain small businesses, and to invest in a child's education or support children in their search for employment.

Similarly, both the United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund, Unicef, and the International Labour Organization, ILO, have found that the interventions of the DSD have not only reduced poverty, but have also improved child nutrition and health, boosted educational outcomes and advanced human development. Their empirical evidence confirms that our impact on people's lives is not to be underestimated.

Hon Chairperson, our impact has been most visible in the educational journeys and achievements of the beneficiaries of the Child Support Grant, CSG. Of the 729 650 registered learners who wrote matric in 2025, the overwhelming majority, that is 84,2%, were recipients of the CSG. The matric pass rate for the social grant beneficiaries rose by 11 percentage points from 74% in 2021 to 84,9% for the class of 2025. Their Bachelor pass rates improved from 33,2% to 41,9% over the same period. Learners receiving the CSG also performed

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exceptionally well in mainstream subjects such as mathematics and physical science.

Indeed, thousands of these learners have gone on to access higher education and training through the National Student Financial Aid Scheme, NSFAS. Those who graduate, get jobs, start businesses and earn income represent our desired return on investment. We will continue to track the occupational destinations and income-earning profiles of these beneficiaries as part of our accounting to this House and to the country at large.

Hon members, we table this Budget Vote under challenging global and domestic conditions. Geopolitical tensions are worsening the cost of living, including the cost of food, fuel and other basic necessities. It is in this context that Budget Vote 19 gives practical expression to His Excellency the President, Mr Ramaphosa's call during Sona 2026 for a nation that works for all and to the Medium-Term Development Plan priorities of inclusive growth and job creation, reducing poverty and the high cost of living, and building a capable and ethical developmental state.

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Hon Chair, allow me now to turn my attention and that of the House to the budget allocation as informed by our annual performance plans for the 2026-27 financial year. Hon members, the department tables a total allocation of R302 billion for the 2026-27 financial year, of which R293 billion is allocated for monthly direct transfers to children, older persons and persons with disabilities as part of our social assistance programme. This includes an amount of R36,4 billion for the continuation of the Covid-19 Social Relief of Distress, SRD, grant, an allocation of R300 million to Sassa to provide for the increased cost of administration of the Covid-19 SRD grant.

An additional amount of R58,4 million was added to the transfer to Sassa for costs related to the incentivised Early Retirement and Voluntary Exit Programmes for 134 employees. An additional allocation of R8,9 million was added to the department's budget for costs related to the incentivised Early Retirement and Voluntary Exit Programme for 12 employees.

We welcome the grant increase announced by the Minister of Finance, while acknowledging that the CSG remains below the

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food poverty line. However, the CSG remains one of the most significant tools to combat child poverty and facilitate transitions to a sustainable livelihood.

Hon Chair and members, you will recall that in the previous financial year, the department outlined ambitious plans incurred on Sassa's modernisation programme and aggressive grant review process. I am encouraged that these efforts are already yielding measurable results. The intensified grant review process has saved the national fiscus over R1 billion, which has been redirected to fund other national priorities.

As of September 2025, Sassa has successfully rolled out the Beneficiary Biometric Enrollment, BBE, system across all its 432 offices. As at the end of March this year, approximately one million new applications were enrolled on this system. Sassa has also expanded the rollout of the Queue Management System from 113 to 378 Sassa offices. The remaining offices will be completed in the first quarter of this financial year.

As the agency expands this digital footprint, we are strengthening cybersecurity to protect beneficiary information and safeguard system integrity. We will also expedite

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lifestyle audits for Sassa employees, beginning with officials in high-risk areas, including grant administration, finance, information and communications technology, ICT, and procurement. Through the District Development Model, Sassa will continue to intensify the Integrated Community Registration Outreach Programme, ICROP, an extensive communication strategy.

We welcome His Excellency the President, Mr Ramaphosa's extension of the Covid-19 SRD grant, until the end of March 2027, to 8 million working-age persons who are unable to support themselves and their families. The department has also made considerable progress since the tabling of the draft basic income support policy to Cabinet, including the finalisation of the costing models.

Work is already underway to link social protection beneficiaries to sustainable livelihood opportunities. The department has partnered with FinMark Trust and are currently piloting a flagship project generating better livelihoods for CSG recipients in the Free State, Gauteng and KwaZulu-Natal. We intend to expand this initiative to all other provinces in the current financial year and beyond.



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Chairperson, an amount of R225 million is allocated to the National Development Agency, NDA, to continue the implementation of its turnaround strategy and to fund approximately 800 civil society organisations. Last year, the department committed to developing and supporting the establishment of community-owned enterprises. To date, the NDA has successfully established nine community-owned enterprises that are creating much-needed job opportunities for young people. To augment its budget and ease its budget pressures, the agency mobilised approximately R40 million. The agency will prioritise strengthening internal controls and raising additional funding resources from both public and private sector partners.

We have set aside R9,9 million to strengthen the work of the Central Drug Authority, CDA, and ensure that the incoming board has the resources it needs at its disposal to execute its mandate. We would want to appoint the board as soon as possible. We are also strengthening the capacity of the CDA secretariat to enhance its administrative and operational efficiency.

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Hon chairperson, Ms Bridget Masango, I read the valid points you raised in the *Sowetan* regarding the CDA. Drug abuse indeed is a crisis. I request that we exchange notes on this matter. But I agree that we have a crisis when it comes to drug abuse.

With regard to nonprofit organisations, NPOs, we will roll out the integrated digital platform for registration and reporting. This platform will enable real-time tracking of compliance and will strengthen co-ordination with key institutions such as the SA Revenue Service and the Companies and Intellectual Property Commission.

Following the classification of gender-based violence and femicide, GBVF, by the President as a national disaster, we are expanding access to shelters and psychosocial support services. We currently provide financial support to 142 shelters across the country. Out of 52 districts across the country, 47 have shelters, leaving only five districts without coverage. Our focus will be on expanding shelters to the remaining five districts in this financial year.

The Gender-Based Violence Command Centre remains a central pillar in our response to GBVF. Since the beginning of this

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year, the centre has received over 39 000 incoming calls. We condemn the recent alleged witchcraft mob justice that claimed the life of a 75-year-old woman and other such incidences in the Eastern Cape. We call on law enforcement to act in a manner that deters these despicable acts of abuse. We call upon all citizens to continue reporting all forms of abuse to the Gender-Based Violence Command Centre on 0800-428-428.

Hon Chair, all of us have a responsibility to protect our children. We are strengthening protection measures against child sexual exploitation, including statutory rape. This work forms part of the Child Protection Month programme currently underway. We are also prioritising measures for children's safety online against this backdrop and many other social ills facing our communities. We wish to indicate that the matter of unemployed social workers will receive our full attention.

Hon members, on the policy and legislative front, we will finalise, among others, the following priority matters: the Sexual and Reproductive Justice Strategy for South Africa, we are finalising consultation on the National Drug Master Plan 2026-2030 at the cluster level, we are finalising the consultation on the Children's Amendment Bill before

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approaching the National Economic Development and Labour Council, Nedlac, we are currently developing regulations to bring the Older Persons Amendment Act into effect, we are also finalising the National Strategy on Ageing for South Africa in line with the United Nations, UN, Decade of Healthy Ageing.

Following the concurrence of the Minister of Public Service and Administration, the department is now implementing the new organisational structure alongside a robust change management transformation process and extensive consultation. We have now embarked on filling all critical posts, including those of the director-general.

Chairperson, I wish to conclude by extending my sincere appreciation to the portfolio committee chairperson, hon Bridget Masango, and the hon members for their continued guidance, the Deputy Minister, hon Ganief Hendricks, the acting director-general, advocate Gugulethu Thimane, the entire DSD team, the chief executive officer of Sassa, Mr Themba Matlou, the team of Sassa, the acting chief executive officer of the NDA, Ms Ramokgopa, the NDA team and the CDA team for their warm welcome and support.

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Hon House Chair and members, it is now my singular honour to table Budget Vote 19 of the DSD before this House and ask for you to please support it. Thank you very much.

*IsiXhosa:*

Nksk T SOKANYILE: Sihlalo weNdlu, maLungu ePalamente ahloniphekileyo, Mphathiswa woPhuhliso loLuntu obambeleyo, Sekela Mphathiswa, abasebenzi beSebe lezoPhuhliso loLuntu, iKomiti yeMicimbi yeSebe lezoPhuhliso loLuntu nabantu baseMzantsi Afrika, molweni.

*English:*

South Africa remains confronted by persistent poverty, unemployment, inequality and deep social vulnerability. Millions of our people continue to rely on the democratic state not because they choose dependency, but because the social construct engineered to subjugate and economically exclude Africans from meaningful opportunities for participation in the economy.

*IsiXhosa:*

Namhlanje, iANC iphakama ngelixhasa ngokupheleleyo iVoti yama34 yeSebe loPhuhliso loLuntu kuba ukhuseleko loluntu

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luhlala lusesona sixhobo esinamandla apho urhulumente wentando yesininzi ubuyisela isidima eluntwini. Ukuqhubeleka phambili nomakulingwane nokhuseleko lwabona bantu baphantsi koxinzelelo lwendlala.

*English:*

This year's budget vote is more vital as we celebrate 20 years of SA Social Security Agency, Sassa.

*IsiXhosa:*

Kukho abantu abandiphazamisayo.

*English:*

SA Social Security Agency commends distributing grants to 11 million beneficiaries and the number of beneficiaries has grown astronomically to approximately 26,5 million. This demonstrates a caring government that prioritises and protects the vulnerable. Social grant must never be viewed as a handout but as an instrument of social justice and human dignity. Social grants are a constitutional response to inequality and practical expression of human dignity.

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Section 27 of the Constitution obliges the state to provide access to social security, including appropriate social assistance for those who are unable to support themselves and their dependents. This understanding is anchored in the values of our liberation movement as succinctly expressed by former President Nelson Mandela who reminded us that:

Overcoming poverty is not a task of charity. It is an act of justice.

Indeed, social grants are not charity. They are justice in action. Hon members and fellow South Africans, the 2025/26 budget vote reaffirmed the importance of threatening social protection, particularly through the continuation of social relief of distress grant and the expansion of grant administration reforms. The extension of the SRD grant not only seeks to cushion the vulnerable but also serve as a stepping stone to a basic income support grant.

The 2026/27 budget vote builds on this foundation ...

*IsiXhosa:*

... le ndigqiba ukuthetha ngayo ...

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*English:*

... by deepening the social wage and ensuring that grant beneficiaries are treated with dignity, efficiency and fairness. The reality is that grants enable survival and participation. A grandmother's pension feeds the entire household. A child support grant keeps children nourished and in school. A disability grant protects the vulnerable citizen from complete destitution. Social relief of distress grant often becomes the only source of hope for unemployed youth searching for work.

Hon Chairperson, we must also acknowledge that while grants provide immediate relief, they also must exist alongside sustainable pathways to economic inclusion. Social grants are not the destination. They are a bridge to a better future. That is why ANC supports stronger linkages between social assistance and economic participation. Beneficiaries, especially the young people, receiving the social relief of distress grant support must be connected to skills development, entrepreneurship opportunities, labour market interventions and pathways to productive employment. Grant must empower people to participate in the economy, not remain trapped at its margins.



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Equally important is improving grant administration. Far too many beneficiaries still experience long queues, payment delays, digital exclusion and frustrating verification process. This budget vote reiterates the ANC's longstanding firm belief that the poor must not be punished for being poor. It does so through prioritising improvement in the administration capacity of the SA Social Security Agency, including stronger digital systems, improved fraud prevention, faster appeals process and better service delivery in rural areas and underserved communities. You can talk about those communities, for instance, Soweto, Kwanyuswa, kuTsolo, Paplas, etc. Hence the ANC says, the efficiency must never come at the expense of the dignity.

Hon members and fellow South Africans, this budget demonstrates an extraordinary desire to fight corruption as it prioritises implementation of the basic income. It understands that we cannot be utilising temporal measures to respond to a crisis of centuries created by colonists and entrenched by the apartheid government. The ANC does not merely view this endeavour as a policy matter but as a moral imperative to leave the vulnerable out of the doldrums of poverty and misery.

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However, the ANC urges the department to expedite the implementation of the basic income grant because rescuing millions of South Africans from poverty is an urgent national priority. This budget vote reaffirms that South Africans cannot defeat poverty while leaving millions without a minimum income flow and that the democratic state, like ours, must be bold enough to protect its people. Hon Chairperson, the Department of Social Development carries one of the most profound responsibilities in our country: ensuring that no South African is left to face hunger, exclusion and hopelessness alone. Supporting this budget ...

*IsiXhosa:*

... kukho abantu ke abaza kuthi ...

*English:*

... we reject this budget.

*IsiXhosa:*

Ibuhlungu ke loo nto kuba aba bantu bathi, ngeliphandle yekani ukufumana ezi zibonelelo ziziswa yi-ANC kweli lizwe.

*English:*

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It means supporting people with disabilities, vulnerable people, unemployed youth and families fighting every day for survival. It means defending dignity.

*IsiXhosa:*

Niyabeve bayangxola xa ndithetha ngokulungiswa kobomi benu.

*English:*

Hon President Ramaphosa eloquently put it as:

Building capable and developmental state that prioritizes the poor.

In line with the President's words, this budget vote and the role of social development is not a secondary function of government, but it is central to nation-building and developmental status.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Hon member, just hold on a moment. Just take your seat. Hon members on the virtual platform, please do not just unmute. I will request the Table staff to be more vigilant in looking for your hands. Hon Reddy, did you want to be recognised and why?

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Mr V G REDDY: Thank you very much. I wanted to know if the hon speaker on the podium, if she is prepared to answer whether ...

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): No, no, no. Thank you, hon Reddy. We firstly inquire whether she is prepared to answer a question. Just stand down.

Mr V G REDDY: Is she prepared to take a question?

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Thank you, hon Reddy. Please mute hon Reddy while I inquire.

Ms T SOKANYILE: Mute that one. Do not ...

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): No, no, no Hon member, I am still to inquire from you. Are you prepared to take a question? Hon Sokanyile, are you prepared to take a question?

Ms T SOKANYILE: I cannot take a question now.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Thank you.

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Ms T SOKANYILE: I am dealing with the most important thing.

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Thank you. Please proceed with your speech then. Order, hon members, let the member conclude.

*IsiXhosa:*

Nksk T SOKANYILE: Bantu baseMzantsi Afrika, xa sithetha ngokulungisa iintlalo zenu, nabo bayangxola, bayandixwaxwa, nibajonge. Maze nincede ningamoshi iivoti zenu.

*English:*

In line with the President's words, this budget vote and the role of social development is not a secondary function of government, but it is central to nation building and developmental strategies.

*IsiXhosa:*

Ze nincede ke ningabavoteli aba. [Kwaphela ixesha.]

*IsiZulu:*

Nk N A MTSHWENI: Sihlalo namalungu ahloniphekileyo ale Ndlu ngiyabingelela siwuMkhonto weSizwe asivumelani ne-GNU. Namuhla

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simi lapha sidingidana nohlelo lonyaka lokusebenza lwevoti lweShumi nesiShagalolunye loMnyango wezokuThuthukiswa Komphakathi. Izinhliziyo zethu zibuhlungu kakhulu ngoba iqiniso elibuhlungu ukuthi esimweni okuso njengamanje uyahluleka ukusiza abantu abampofu baseNingizimu Afrika.

Sihlalo cishe ingxenye eningi yabantu bakulelizwe incike ezibonelelweni zikahulumeni ukuze bakwazi ukuphila. Lokho kukodwa kusikhombisa ngokusobala ukuthi ububha buyanda kunokuba behle. Umbuzo okufanele sizibuze wona ...

*English:*

The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Hon member, just please hold on for a moment. Can the table staff please attend to the translation services? It's not available at the moment.

*IsiZulu:*

Nk N A MTSHWENI: Umbuzo okufanele sizibuze wona ukuthi lukhona yini uhlelo lokuqeda ububha? Likhona yini uhlelo lokubuyisela isithunzi kubantu bakithi? Omunye umbuzo okufanele sizibuze wona ukuthi likhona yini izwe elinabantu abaningi kangaka abaphila ngezibonelelo?

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UMnyango ugqugquzela ububha kunokuba ubugede. Abantu bakithi bayaqhubeka nokuhlupheka kodwa imibiko nezinhlelo zikahulumeni zigcwele amazwi amakhulu angasiguquli isimo alethe ushintsho olubonakalayo emphakathini. Abantu abampofu sebekhathele yizethembiso ezingabonakali, bafuna izenzo ezibonakalayo.

Sihlalo ukusetshenziswa kwezidakamizwa kuqede imiphakathi yakithi. Izidakamizwa zibulala ikusasa lentsha yethu. Imindeni iyahlukumezeka, ubugebengu buyanda nemiphakathi isiphila ngokwesaba kodwa uMnyango awunalo uhlelo olucacile nolusebenzayo lokuhlenga abantu bakithi kule nkinga yezidakamizwa. Le-APP ayinazo izimpendulo.

Namuhla njengoba sikhuluma u-CDA akanawo umkhandlu olawulayo okuyiwo okumele uhole ukulwa nezidakamiswa emphakathini. Uhulumeni angasho kanjani ukuthi uzumisele ukulwa nezidakamizwa kuyilapho uhlaka olubaluleke kangaka lungasebezi. Izinhlangano zomphjakathi, amasonto, ama-NGO kanye nezinye izikhungo zokuhlunyeleliswa kwezimilo bayazama ukusiza abantu bakithi kodwa abatholi uxhaso olwanele kulo Mnyango. Izinhlangano eziningi ziyawa ziyahluleka ngenxa yokuthi azilutholi usizo lwezimali kuhulumeni.

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Sihlalo ohloniphekileyo, abesifazane bayaqhubeka nokuhlukumezeka nsuku zonke. Udlame olubhekiswe kwabesifazane nezingane seluphenduke inhlekelele kaZwelonke. Sihlalo, abesifazane nezingane udlame olubhekiswe kubo seluphenduke inhlekelele kaZwelonke. Abesifazane nezingane bakhala befuna ukuvikelwa kodwa abalutholi usizo. Uma owesifazane osendaweni yasemakhaya eQumbu ehluKumezeka phakathi kwamabili kufanele abalekele kuphi uma uMnyango ungekho lapho?

Ake sikhulume ngoSassa. Njengeqembu loMkhonto weSizwe sifuna ukukusho ngokucacile ukuthi izikhungo zokuholela kufanele zibuyiselwe ezindaweni zabantu. UMnyango wavala izikhungo zokuholela ngaphandle kokubheka umonakalo omkhulu owadaleka emphakathini nasemnothweni wabantu abansundu. Lezi zikhungo kwakungekhona nje ukuthola izibonelelo kulezo zindawo kwakuyimpilo nomnotho wabantu abansundu.

Ake uhambe Ngqongqoshe uyobuka izindawo zasemakhaya la okwakuyizikhungo zokuholela khona sengathi ungayofika kwaMhlabuyalingana eNtshongwe esikhungweni esasisikhulu kakhulu uyobabona bafike bebakaza phansi kwezihlala bengazi ukuthi bazokwenzenjani. Izikhungo zokuholela kwakusebenzela kuzo osomabhizinisi abancane, abadayisayo, abahwebi



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ababedayisa ngamaklabishi nangezimphahla zokugqoka.  
Kwizikhungo zokuholela kwakusizakala abantu bezitolo  
zasemakhaya ezagcina zivaliwe ngenxa yokuvalwa kwezikhungo.  
Iqiniso olaziyo Ngqongqoshe ukuthi ziningi izifundiswa  
ezazalwa yilolo hlelo lolo lokudayisa ezikhungweni zokuholela.  
Udaba lwezikhungo zokuholela lwaphazamisa impumelelo eningi  
kakhulu.

Ku-APP edlule salukhuma lolu daba sisaqhubeka futhi sicela  
izikhungo zibuyele. Abantu abadala babehamba amabanga  
amafushane ukuyothola izibonelelo zabo kodwa namhlanje bahamba  
amabanga amade. Kufuneka bagibele ngemali abangenayo,  
banqamule ubusuku ukuyobamba olayini abade. Babanjwe  
yizigebengu futhi kulezo zindawo lezo. Sengathi  
ningayibukisisa leyo ndaba leyo. Asikwazi ukuqhubeka siphathe  
abantu abadala ngale ndlela le. UNkulunkulu uyosahlulela  
ngalokho ngoba abantu abadala yibo abakhulekela izwe futhi  
yibona abalwela le nkululeko lena. Uma sifuna isibusiso  
kufanele ukuthi sisinake isililo sabantu abadala. Asilalele  
iziwi lokukhala kwabo.

Sihlalo ohloniphekileyo siphinde sikhulume ngo NDA. U-NDA  
uthola imali akwazi ukuholela ngayo abantu abasebenza kuye.

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Angakwazi ukwakha amabhizinisi amancane okwelekelela abantu ukuze kuqedwe ububha nokweswela emphakathin. Imali ayitholayo igcina isisize izisebenzi ukuthi mazihole kodwa ukuthi kwakhiwe amabhizinisi azokolekelela abantu akwenzeki lokho. Sihlalo angibuye futhi.

NjengoMkhonto weSizwe sidinga uMnyango ovikela abesifazane nezingane. NjengoMkhonto weSizwe sidinga uMnyango oxhasa ama-NGO nezinhlango zomphakathi. NjengoMkhonto weSizwe sidinga uMnyango ohlonipha abantu abadala. NjengoMkhonto weSizwe sidinga uMnyango ozozwelana nabantu abadala bangaze baphume beyomasha emgwaqeni nezindondolo begugile beyocela ukuthi lizwakale izwi labo. Okube yihlazo elikhulu kakhulu ukuthi uma abantu abadala bekhushulelwa imali banikezwe uR80 kulesi simo esibi kangaka esibhekene naso lapho wonke umuntu ebona ukuthi kusinda kangakani ukuphila. Siyacela nibuye nikubukisise futhi lokho.

NgoMhlaka-4 kuLwezi iNingizimu Afrika izovota kuwo lonyaka lo. Siyacela kubantu baseNingizimu Afrika ukuthi uvoteleni uMkhonto weSizwe ukuze uzilethe lezidingo, ulethe umehluko ukuzwelana nabantu, ukuzwelana nabantu abadala, ukuzwelana nezingane, ukuzwelana nezintandane, ukuzwelana nabantu abaphila

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nokukhubazeka abahamba amabanga amade beyolanda imali la  
ihanjiswe khona konxiwankulu. Angithokoze Sihlalo.

Ms B S MASANGO: Hon House Chairperson, hon Acting Minister,  
hon Deputy Minister, hon members, ladies and gentlemen, good  
afternoon. This debate takes place at a time when several  
critical issues continue to affect the Department of Social  
Development. From a policy perspective, it is important to  
note that during the Sixth Administration, the department was  
developing the critically important White Paper on Social  
Development.

Parliament was informed on several occasions that this policy  
was at an advanced stage of development and had eventually  
been tabled before Cabinet for approval. However, progress on  
this work can no longer be clearly tracked despite the fact  
that it was understood to form the basis for the development  
of the broader Social Development Act.

The absence of this policy from the department's plans is  
gravely concerning. The delays in finalising this policy and  
its related legislation continue to negatively affect service

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delivery, accountability, and the optimal functioning of the department itself.

Additionally, we remain deeply concerned and disappointed by the manner in which the department is currently managing other critical pieces of legislation. For example, the finalisation timelines for the Children's Amendment Bill have been again extended without concrete explanation. This demonstrates a troubling lack of appreciation for the impact this legislation has on the provision of services to South African' children.

South Africa's children are stunted. Some suffer and die from malnutrition. Others are abandoned, abused, and in some cases lose their lives. This list continues. Yet the Children's Act clearly states that the best interests of the child are paramount in every matter concerning the care, the protection, and well-being of children. Why has the Office of the Rights of the Child not yet been relocated to the Presidency to ensure the smooth implementation of the national strategy to accelerate action for children?

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The hon President pronounced on this urgent matter, yet parliamentary questions directed to the department have been met with flippant responses.

The lives of children must be more important than that. The commendable work done by the department on the Older Persons Act has unfortunately been undermined by the department's deeply concerning silence on the development of the regulations required to guide its full implementation.

Of serious concern in this regard is the department reneging on its commitments to conduct a roadshow of residential care facilities for older persons. We are all aware of gross violations of human rights against our senior citizens. The department must provide clear timelines in this regard.

South Africa continues to experience one of the highest rates of gender-based violence in the world. Between April and September 2025, SA Police Service, SAPS recorded 24,417 sexual offense cases, 19,387 rapes, and more than 3,400 sexual assaults. Many incidents, of course, go unreported, highlighting the devastating scale of this crisis.

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This is why the department must return the Victim Support Services Bill to legislative process without further delay. We cannot expect to win the fight against gender-based violence while critical legislation remains stalled.

On matters relating to substance abuse, South Africa remains among the hardest affected countries. Yet the term of the Central Drug Authority expired in March 2026, effectively leaving the coordination, overseeing, monitoring and evaluation of government's response to substance abuse at a standstill. The department was fully aware that the board's term was coming to an end, yet no measures were put in place to ensure the timely appointment of a new board. This is worse than business as usual. A mandate of this magnitude cannot be left to chance. There must be a seamless continuity in the coordination of government's response to substance abuse.

On matters of accountability, the department has still not honoured its undertaking to provide a detailed breakdown of the cost relating to the taxpayers' R3 million reportedly spent on a New York trip.

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In closing, while acknowledging the progress the department has made, oversight also requires us to confront areas where urgency, accountability and implementation remain lacking so that corrective action can be taken.

Having said that, I wish to take this opportunity to commend both the national, provincial and local departments of Social Development together with all stakeholders in the sector for the work they continue to do in delivering critical services to the vulnerable people of South Africa. Thank you, hon House Chair.

Ms P MARAIS: Hon House Chairperson, I would like to acknowledge my commander-in-chief, CIC, officials, commissars, fighters and ground forces. Hon Minister, I rise to participate in the debate of Budget Vote No 19 the budget allocation for the Department of Social Development. At the stage of this debate lies a difficult but unavoidable truth.

South Africans remain one of the unequal societies in the world. Millions of our people continue to live below poverty line. Unemployment remains stubbornly high. Gender-based violence continue to tear families apart. Substance abuse is

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destroying communities. Vulnerable children and older persons remain dependent on the state for survival. Therefore, social development cannot merely be viewed as another expenditure item into the fiscus. It is a constitutional obligation; it is an instrument of social justice. It is a moral commitment to the poor. The unemployed, the elderly women, children, persons with disabilities and all those remain excluded from meaningful economic participation.

The people of South Africa do not simply expect budgets to be tabled, they expect budgets to translate into dignity, service delivery, accountability and measurable outcomes.

The first concern with this budget is that it continues imbalance between the social relieve and substantial economic empowerment. The department continue to allocate overwhelming majority of its budgets towards social grants and income support. While social grants remain essential in cushioning millions of our households against extreme poverty, the reality is that grants alone cannot eradicate poverty permanently.



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South Africans cannot afford a welfare state without a parallel strategy for economic inclusion. The dependency ratio continues to grow, while economic growth remains weak. More people are becoming dependent on the state, while fewer taxpayers are carrying the financial and fiscal burden. This raises a serious policy question. Where is the long-term strategy to transit vulnerable households from the social dependency towards economic self-sufficiency?

The Expanded Public Works Programme, community development initiatives, youth empowerment programmes, skills development interventions, support of nonprofit organisations remain underscored, volitive and the scale of the crises confronting our communities.

The second concern relates to administrative efficiencies and weakness in governance. The Auditor-General has repetitively raised concerns regarding weakness in internal controls, poor record-keeping, unreliable performance, information and inadequate subsequent management within the department and some of its entities.

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Most concerning is that the Department of Social Development receive a qualified audit opinions with findings for the 2024-25 financial year. A qualified audit outcome is not a minor administrative issue, it signals material weakness in financial management and raises concerns about whether public resources are being utilised effectively, transparently and full compliance with the Public Finance Management Act.

The Auditor-General specifically identified weakness relating to data systems, incomplete supporting documents and limited systems integrated for identifying illegible beneficiaries. This particular alarm because the department's administrative is one of the largest social protection systems on the African continent. When systems are weak, opportunities for fraud, duplication, corruption, irregular expenditure, inevitable increase.

The Auditor-General also highlighted broader concern regarding noncompliance with the legislation, material missed statements and performance reports and persistence governance failure.

This House must ask: How can we justify increase allocations when accountability mechanism remain insufficient? The issue before us is not only where the money is spent. The issue is

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where the money is spent effectively, lawfully and in a manner that generally improves the lives of our people.

Another major shortcoming in the Budget Vote 19 is continued vulnerability of the social grant payment system. Yes, year-after-year beneficiaries complain about delayed payments, long queues, system failures, network outreach, inaccessible service points in the rural communities and difficult links to Post Office migration process.

For many South Africans a social grant is not a supplementary income, it is the only income. Any insufficiency within the grant system directly affects food security, house responsibility and human dignity. We cannot continue normalise the situation where the elderly beneficiaries stand in queues for hours, under harsh weather conditions merely to access constitutionally protected support.

The department must also confront the growing crises in substance abuse, homelessness, child neglect, gender-based violence and it must act with far greater emergency.

Community-based organisations and nonprofit organisations, NPOs, remain the backbone of this social intervention in many

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communities. Yet many continue to experience delay, transfers, inadequate funding and unassailable operational conditions.

Far too many social workers remain overburdened. Far too many shelters operate without sufficient support from the state. Far too many children fall through the cracks of the child protection system. Far too many victims of gender-based violence encountered a fragmented support framework. If social development is truly a national priority, then frontline social services must receive greater investment and strong institutional support.

We also acknowledge the broader fiscal context within which the budget is being tabled. South Africa faces ... The EFF cannot accept this budget. Thank you. [Time expired.]

Ms B E MACHI: Hon House Chairperson, thank you so much. The IFP welcomes Budget Vote 19 because we see social services not as sharing but as an investment in human dignity and resilience. For millions of South Africans who face hardship, these measures provide immediate relieve while laying the groundwork for genuine economic participation.

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Reliable social services must do more than keep people afloat. They must develop and empower them to stand on their own. Contribute meaningfully to the nation's future.

While we recognise the department's extensive reach, our support for the allocation is coupled with the firm demand for accountability regarding critical structural failure. We must acknowledge the difficult truth that our current system risk becoming a framework for bureaucratic compliance rather than a collective instrument for genuine human development. At the same time, the exclusion of our most vulnerable children is deeply troubling.

In the midst of the nation in crises of early childhood, struggling and malnutrition, The SA Social Security Agency, erases the target to reach children under two-years-old, from its annual performance plan. We cannot claim to build a healthy, capable future workforce while ignoring our children during the foundation phase, their early development.

The IFP demands, the immediate reinstatement for these targets. Protecting our children must go beyond mere cash transfers. Officials must be deployed directly to health care

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facilities to streamline early registration and ensure no child is left behind.

We must also confront the technological exclusive affection to our rural and elderly populations. While fraud defected systems are necessary and rigid roll-out of biometric verification and remote auditing has turned technology into barrier rather than an enabler. These failures have already caused a significant drop in earlier grants, leaving thousands of frails rural and biological, illiterate citizens cut off from their only source of survival. Accessible, face-to-face alternative and mobile outreach units must be deployed immediately so that no legitimate beneficiary is left behind by the technology divide.

We must further address the National Development Agency's internal inefficiencies. It is unacceptable that nearly 87% of its budget is consumed by fixed and employee-related operating costs, living only a fraction for delivery and civil society funding. This is not real development of almost of its budget goes to salaries and running costs while very little reaches communities. Our vulnerable communities deserve consistence and effective social services that work for them and not only

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for the system that is empowered. In light of the issues raised, the IFP supports Budget Vote 19. I thank you.

Ms S M PETERS: House Chair, hon Acting Minister, hon Deputy Minister and hon members, the PA supports interventions that protect the poor, restore dignity to vulnerable communities and ensure that no South African is left behind. Social development is not a charity. It's a constitutional responsibility and a moral obligation.

We welcome the child support grant top-up and the fact that it now exceeds the food poverty line. This is an important intervention for vulnerable children.

The PA also believes that the annual increase of only R80 to the old age grant is inadequate. Our pensioners are carrying enormous burdens, raising grandchildren, supporting unemployed family members and trying to survive in an economy where food, electricity and transport costs continue to rise. Elderly citizens who built this country deserve more than symbolic increases that fail to meet their daily needs.

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The delay in finalising the Basic Income Support policy is deeply concerning. Millions of South Africans rely on the social relief of distress, SRD, grant as their only form of income, yet there is still uncertainty about what will happen after March 2027. Government cannot continue delaying critical decisions while people are struggling to put food on the table.

The PA supports the principle that social assistance must also create pathways to economic empowerment. Grants should not trap people in poverty. They should serve as a support while beneficiaries are linked to real opportunities through skills development and entrepreneurship, as well as employment programmes.

However, the current pace is far too slow. Creating just over 209 000 work opportunities through the Expanded Public Works Programme, EPWP, in a country with almost eight million unemployed people is simply not enough. South Africa needs sustainable jobs and long-term economic opportunities, not temporary relief that disappears after a few months.



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We are especially alarmed by the ongoing crisis of gender-based violence, GBV, and child abuse in our communities. Girls as young as 10-years-old continue to fall pregnant and face high-risk exploitation, abuse and HIV infection, yet the department plans only four awareness campaigns and four additional GBV shelters. The PA believes that this crisis requires far more urgency and far stronger intervention.

The National Development Agency must be strengthened. With nearly 70% of its budget going to salaries, we must ask how much is truly reaching communities and driving poverty eradication?

We also remain concerned about the exclusion of persons with disabilities. Many children with disabilities still cannot access schools, while government facilities, including SA Social Security Agency, Sassa, offices, remain inaccessible. Inclusion cannot remain a slogan while vulnerable people continue to face daily barriers.

The department has been marked by persistent underperformance and weak oversight, and this during the time of the former Minister.

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I want to go to the food aide, because my time is almost up. I just want to say that it is pure extortion that the Minister's daughter applied for the food aide. I want to ask the following. How is that different to the previous times in our lives? How is it different to apartheid? The PA supports the Vote. Thank you.

Mr P A VAN STADEN: House Chairperson, first of all, I welcome the Acting Minister. I wish you all the best with your task in this department.

Upon reading the portfolio committee's recommendations in this report, one is compelled to question how the department utilised its R295 billion allocation for 2025-26 and how it intends to manage the increased budget of R302 billion for 2026-27.

All eight recommendations of the committee in this report begin with the phrase, the Minister should ensure. However, what stands out most is the third recommendation, which states that the Minister should also ensure that the department produces annual reports of a high standard before they are published and submitted to Parliament. It is therefore hardly

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surprising that the President dismissed the Minister last Thursday in light of allegations against her.

Equally, it comes as no surprise that this report repeatedly states that the Minister should ensure this or that. The simple truth is that the Minister failed to do her job. Why are we still discussing the Central Drug Authority's, CDA's, need for a transparent budget allocation, expenditure and accountability frameworks? It's because the Minister did not do her job.

Why are we still grappling with the lack of front-line staff at Sassa offices and the persistent problem of long queues? Once again, because the Minister did not do her job. ... plain and simple, yet somehow the Minister found the time to appoint a 55-year-old individual, only to misuse her by sending her to ... duties at her private residence in East London, where she was required to care for the Minister's grandchildren, while also performing domestic work such as laundry and cleaning.

However, most troubling of all ... the Minister allegedly went further, pressurising this woman to pay R7 000 of her R15 000 salary to the Minister's daughter. When the Minister

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later appeared before this committee, the same woman, now traumatised and pursuing legal action against this department, was represented by legal counsel who publicly stated that the Minister had not given truthful testimony in front of this committee.

Instead, in this report we are confronted with a repeated refrain that the Minister should ensure. What an awful shame! It is deeply troubling that a Minister who was entrusted with the care and protection of society's most vulnerable, particularly the elderly, has so clearly failed to fulfil her duties. Rather than upholding this responsibility, she instead found time to orchestrate the exploitation of a hardworking individual for personal gain.

Last Friday, we saw what happened. The President declined to disclose the reasons, findings or reports that informed his decision to remove this Minister, to Parliament. That speaks volumes. The people of South Africa have a right to know exactly what transpired within this department.

I therefore again call on the President, and now on the Acting Minister to talk to the President, to once again disclose

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before Parliament the reasons, findings or reports that informed his decision to remove the previous Minister from Cabinet.

As I said, Acting Minister, I wish you well in your task in this department, but I don't think it's going to be easy. We are sitting with big problems in this department and I hope it can be solved by you. Thank you, Chairperson.

Ms D E JAMES: ... [No audio.] ... South Africans, billions upon billions of rand flowing through the department every single year. There are pensioners choosing whether they should cook food or whether they should have electricity, flee from their homes, surrender their Sassa cards to their drug-addicted children while waiting for social workers to come to their rescue, persons with disabilities laying in their urine for days on end.

Minister, I sent you a WhatsApp ... last week. You haven't responded to it. ... an old age home in Eersterust where people are being abused. I await your response. Yet, instead of stability, integrity and competent governance, they are subjected to endless political games, cadre deployment,

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corruption and internal warfare. A department tasked with protecting the most vulnerable in society has in itself become an instrument of corruption, patronage, suffering and decay.

*Afrikaans:*

Hierdie departement kan nie so aangaan nie.

*English:*

South Africans deserve better than this circus. They deserve a department led by people of integrity, not politically connected looters and deployees.

Minister, it is also not only now that we are left without the CDA. This country is experiencing a drug crisis. It has been since March 2025 ... the CDA was told to stop working because there's no money to actually pay them. It's a disgrace that two months into the new term, we still don't have a CDA. Please, can you attend to that as a matter of urgency?

People deserve to be led by a department of integrity and not politically connected looters like we have seen. For these reasons, and because there is simply no confidence in the stability, credibility or leadership of this department,

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Action SA says it cannot and it will not support this budget.  
I thank you.

The DEPUTY MINISTER OF SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT: Hon Chairperson,  
Acting Minister of Social Development, members of the  
portfolio committee, distinguished guests, ladies and  
gentlemen, hon members on the virtual platform and those who  
honoured us with their presence ...

*IsiZulu:*

... sanibonani.

*English:*

Today we table Budget Vote 19 at a time when millions of South  
Africans rely on the social wage for dignity, hope and  
survival. Hope that this is the foundation for sustainable  
livelihoods, especially for those beneficiaries receiving  
child support grants and entering the adult world, they want a  
pathway to a paycheque and even dividends as they get into  
business.

This year we proudly celebrate 20 years of the SA Social  
Security Agency, SASSA. For two decades SASSA has advanced

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dignity, inclusion and social justice, becoming a vital pillar of our democracy.

Having, in its 20th year, turned the corner dramatically and on the radar a 90-minute queues and service while you wait in the queue, is something to look forward to.

The Department is tabling Department of Social Development Budget Vote 19 under the theme: *Strengthening Social Protection and Celebrating 20 Years of SASSA: Delivering Dignity, Enabling the Future.*

Hon Chair, allow me to now focus on delegations that were allocated to me by the department's former Minister as they are at the centre of providing essential and critical services to our communities across the country.

The first delegation is families and parenting programmes. Families are at the receiving end of poverty and have a first-hand experience of the effects of disasters. A case in point are the floods that we recently experienced here in Cape Town, affecting 15 000 people; and I haven't heard a word about the distress that they are having.



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Yesterday, as a built-up to this budget vote, we distributed food parcels and blankets to some of the flooded areas in ward 5, farm dwellers of Soetendal in the Drakenstein Municipality. These farm dwellers were evicted and are still waiting for formal housing.

During the heavy rains in Limpopo, a granny wanted a tent and I responded with two: one for a church with beds, mattresses, blankets, pillows, a washbasin and a fire extinguisher. We now have a solar-powered globe bulb for the tent to charge her cell phone. Grannies know all about data. This is a message to all cell phone companies, when an older person gets your sim-card and know their age, data must be free and fast.

Hon Chair, we continue to mitigate effects of poverty on families through various supporting programmes like Chommy, YOLO, You Only Live Once; many of hon members here actually live twice. So, we continue to mitigate effects of poverty on families through various supporting programmes, taking services to the most vulnerable people; a legacy Mandela wanted to see. This includes interactive dialogues, psychosocial support and programmes guided by the White Paper on Families.

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SASSA is at the forefront with the Integrated Community Registration Outreach Programme, ICROP, to give over the counter letters of confirmation of successful applicants and the National Development Agency, NDA, is there to assist, helping to establish co-operatives.

I have attended a dozen ICROP, nearly 5 000 people and have witnessed that the service provided is appreciated by communities. They came in the morning and then in the afternoon I was asked to present them with a letter to say that the application has been successful and they even get the date when they can get their first draw.

So, Central Drug Authorities, CDAs, are also helping to establish co-operatives. Fifty CDAs in Winterveldt, Northern Cape, have recently been creating pathways for employment. The Department of Social Development has taken government services to thousands of people in rural constituencies.

As a build-up to this budget vote, the Department of Social Development visited Vrygrond to witness the excellent work done by the National Development Agency, NDA, creating

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pathways for young people to employment and also to start their own businesses.

Chair, you must remember that our freedom was built on the resistance in Vrygrond. I was very happy that the Acting Minister found time to join the event in Vrygrond.

Alongside this development, the NDA established strategic partnerships with nonprofit organisations, NPOs, and empowered communities. Over the years, the NDA partnered with civil society organisations to provide food security, skills development, and creation of job opportunities to support and strengthen families.

Let me applaud our Sector Education and Training Authorities, Setas, for supporting the NDA. Just in two months with the new budget here, the NDA can now direct nearly R40 million to organisations addressing youth employment. On the radar is the cell phone ... proper phone project and very soon South Africa will take over this lucrative enterprise.

I want to talk about substance abuse and the Central Drug Authority, CDA. It's an authority, not a board. Substance

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abuse, which has affected many families, continues to rob many individuals of their future and it contributes significantly to, among others, gender-based violence and femicide, GBVF, crime and the alcohol ... [Inaudible.] ... rates.

Alcohol abuse is the main cause of gender-based violence and the reason why we now have a state of disaster; there is no other reason, it's only alcohol abuse.

I commend Checkers for withdrawing their application for a liquor license this month in Pinelands. This is the contribution by the retail sector to combat gender-based violence.

The department's dedicated unit is determined to implement intervention programmes against this menace, a scourge that persistently destroy families and communities, especially vulnerable children, youth, women and older persons, including persons with disabilities.

We applaud the Premier of Gauteng whom I joined in Tembisa and on one day, recently at a local sports field, we got 500 beds for young people to get drug rehabilitation treatment.

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On 26 June is the United Nations, UN, International World Drug Day. No to Drugs and Yes to Life, we plan to tell up to 2 000 participants to commemorate the event. So, the department is very active in addressing matters relating to drug abuse, and this will be the event of the year.

Hon Chair, while I have the delegation for substance abuse, top of mind is to continue supporting a newly appointed Central Drug Authority. We are still waiting for Parliament to submit to us the names and we have written to the Speaker to please fast track it so that we can have a Central Drug Authority in operation. But in the meantime, the department and the provinces and even some Mayors are doing tremendous work when it comes to matters relating to drugs.

So, the Central Drug Authority conducts oversight and reports on all of government's contributions on prevention and treatment services.

We will work on giving effect on a recent judgement of the North West High Court reminding the country that no liquor outlet must operate within 500 meters from a school, church or public amenity, and that trading hours must be in terms of

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national norms, in support of a final Cabinet policy agreed to nine years ago.

Hon Chair, we believe that reducing alcohol trading hours reduces alcohol harm and violence against women.

I note that there is a Private Members Bill to ban liquor advertising. Well done fighters!

I want to advocate a ban on alcohol trading in 100 of our hotspots following the example of my own neighbourhood in Pinelands, which is a dry neighbourhood and where I lived before in Kalk Bay. I lived in areas that are dry, but I also understand how that will benefit many other suburbs in the country.

I'm not saying that South Africa must now be a dry country, because that won't be popular, but we need to have that on top of mind.

Hon Chair, to this effect, an amount of more than R9 million is reprioritised from the Department of Social Development's budget, and not new money, and allocated to the CDA for

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increased operational costs to do their oversight on 21 government departments who have been given a budget to implement their part of a five-year Drug Master Plan as well as reporting on the work of every Mayor in the country responsible to establish and fund a Local Drug Action Committee in their municipality.

Mayors have agreed to be in the frontline to combat and fight gender-based violence, and we need to get more and more Mayors to do so.

The CDA submits an annual report to Parliament on their achievements. The Department of Social Development has a legal obligation to develop a five-year Drug Master Plan which is ... [Time expired.] ... submitted to Cabinet. Thank you very much.

Ms C T NONTENJA: Hon House Chair, I rise to present the UDM's input on vote 19. The government continues to speak about reducing poverty, empowering communities and protecting vulnerable citizens. Yet, this report reveals a very different reality. It exposes slow implementation, delayed policies,

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failing systems and an increasing dependence on social grants instead of sustainable economic opportunities.

Hon House Chair, besides social policy and integrated service delivery, which has a real increase of 3,15% and administration with almost 2% real increase, all the other programmes of this department are on a decrease, in real terms, which amounts to an average of minus 0,94%.

This highlights the fact that when budgeting for such a crucial department it doesn't assist to apply nominal figures instead of real figures.

The reality is that most of this department's programme allocations decreased, with a negative impact on the most vulnerable citizens.

Millions of South Africans still rely on social assistance simply to survive, while unemployment remains critically high. At the same time, communities continue to suffer for gender-based violence and welfare services face severe funding and staffing shortages.



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South Africans do not only want survival, they want dignity, opportunity, safety and a future. South Africa's social crisis is deepening despite repeated government promises.

The country's unemployment rate increased to 32,7% in the first quarter of 2026, with more than 8,1 million South Africans unemployed.

While youth unemployment continues to rise sharply, serious weaknesses in government service delivery are exposed through SASSA offices that continue to experience long queues, outdated systems and administrative inefficiencies, despite promises of digital transformation.

The UDM calls on the department to consider cost of living and inflation when budgeting and use real figures instead of nominal figures.

The UDM supports the budget.

*Xitsonga:*

Tat S M GANA: Mutshamaxitulu, ...

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*English:*

I will be very relevant today and say ...

*IsiZulu:*

... bazobuya nayo abafana eMbombela ngoMgqibelo.

*English:*

Hon Minister, why is it harder for people to get their grants than it is to gamble? I often tell the story of walking outside the Post Office during the COVID-19 pandemic and seeing the line of young people waiting for their COVID-19 social relief of distress grant, SRD. At the same time, the lines at the betting shops were just as full. And, I can promise you, Minister, that it would have been twice as easy to gamble away that grant than it was to obtain it.

Convoluting and complex application and verification processes stopped many South Africans from accessing the grants that they desperately need. Grants that they could have been used to buy food, pay rent or even start a business. We recently saw in Everton, Gauteng, how over a thousand SRD grant recipients came together and put their money into a stokvel to start a bakery. A bakery that now not only provides daily

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bread to the community but sustains thousands of families. Despite this potential, we still see SA Social Security Agency, Sassa, losing hundreds of millions to fraudsters and scammers.

The solution is clear. Prioritise making grants easily accessible to those who qualify. We have seen it time and time again, simplifying bureaucratic processes decreases fraud. The less complicated and convoluted steps there are, the less space for fraudsters and scammers to take advantage of the most vulnerable. The simpler it is, the more people can truly benefit without sacrificing their dignity in long queues, only to be turned away time and time again because the system is offline.

This desperation also turns even those who do get their grants into gambling. We have had countless reports of the National Student Financial Aid Scheme, NSFAS, and Sassa recipients using that little they have to gamble, many in the hope that they can make the R370 stretch a little bit further, but it really doesn't. The gambling crisis we find ourselves in did not come out of nowhere, it arose from easy access and desperation.

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Minister, I've addressed your predecessor on many occasions on this issue, urging her to take action. I hope this is another area where your tenure, however long it is, will show better results. I trust that you will act swiftly so that when we return next year, I will not have to ask again, why is it harder for people to get their grants than it is to gamble?

*IsiZulu:*

Abafana bayobuya nayo eMbombela ngoMgqibelo.

*Xitsonga:*

Ndza khensa, Mutshamaxitulu.

*English:*

Once and always.

*Sesotho:*

Ngaka L W MAHLATSI: Kgotso, Maafrica!

*English:*

Budget Vote 19 speaks to the moral core of our constitutional democracy. The mandate of the Department of Social Development is not administrative, it is humanitarian. It exists to

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protect the most vulnerable; the children, older persons, persons with disabilities and the families trapped in intergenerational poverty. Yet, year after year, we appropriate billions without seeing the corresponding reduction in vulnerability, hunger and social distress.

South Africa has over 18 million beneficiaries administered by Sassa. This is not a success statistic. It is an alarm bell. It tells us that our social protection system is expanding, while Social Development outcomes are stagnating. The Auditor-General reflects with contract management, beneficiary verification failure and irregular expenditure. When corruption infiltrates social grants, it is not just financial misconduct, it is a theft from the poorest.

Equally troubling is the collapse of the nongovernmental organisations, NGOs, funding model. Shelter, early childhood development, ECD, centres and disability organisations close because subsidies arrive late or not at all. Yet, the NGOs are the department' implementing arm at community level. We must also confront the narrative presented by the Deputy Minister, who speaks proudly of food parcels and tents provided to the vulnerable communities. That is emergency relief, not social

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development. It keeps people alive for a day. It does not change their condition.

By contrast, the UAT advanced the self-determination, creating conditions where people sustain themselves with dignity. Where governments speak of tents, UAT build houses for the vulnerable. Where governments distribute food parcels, UAT promote livelihood, skills and community resilience. Social grants must be a safety net, not a permanent destination. The UAT reject Budget Vote 19 and encourage all South Africans to vote for the UAT on the 4 November.

*Xitsonga:*

Khanimambo!

Mr I ISMAIL-MOOSA: Hon Chairperson, in the name of the Almighty, the most gracious and the most merciful, I greet all our beloved family of South Africans in the name and prayer of peace. Firstly, let me take the opportunity to acknowledge the sterling and dedicated work of our hon Deputy Minister, Ganief Hendricks, the leader of Al Jama-ah, who remains steadfast and committed to uplifting the lives of the vulnerable within the

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Department of Social Development. His dedication and sacrifice in serving our people continue to make our country proud.

Al Jama-ah votes and supports Vote 19 on Social Development. At a time when poverty, unemployment, substance abuse, gender-based violence and child neglect continue to affect millions of South Africans, Social Development remains a critical pillar of dignity and hope for our people. We call for greater support for vulnerable communities, improved protection for women, children, the elderly and persons living with disabilities, as well as stronger oversight to ensure that social grants and essential services reach those most in need.

Al Jama-ah further urges government to strengthen partnerships with community organisations, faith-based institutions and civil society in restoring the social fabric of our nation. A caring society is not measured by wealth but how it protects and uplifts its most vulnerable citizens. We must also acknowledge the growing crisis faced by many young people trapped in cycles of unemployment, hopelessness, gangsterism and drug abuse.

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Social Development programmes must not only provide relief but also empowerment, skills development, rehabilitation and pathways towards sustainable livelihoods. The fight against poverty cannot be won by government alone. It requires collective responsibility, ethical leadership and compassionate governance that places humanity before politics. We must ensure that every child sleeps with dignity, every elderly citizen is treated with respect and every struggling family feels that government does not abandon them.

Al Jama-ah believes that social justice, compassion and human dignity are values that must guide this department at all times. We further call for improved efficiency in the distribution of grants, stronger support systems for social workers on the ground and greater accountability to ensure public resources are utilised responsibly and effectively. As leaders entrusted by the people of South Africa, we have a moral duty to restore hope to the forgotten, uplift the downtrodden and build a nation rooted in unity, care and justice for all. Thank you. [Time expired.]

*IsiZulu:*

Malibongwe!



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Ms N K SHARIF: House Chair, the Department of Social Development has been plagued by scandal, instability, financial mismanagement and a serious lack of leadership and direction. A great deal of work is needed to restore this department and ensure that it works for the people of South Africa.

We welcome the removal of former Minister Sisi Tolashe after sustained pressure from the DA. The DA laid its first ethics complaint on 19 October 2025, wrote to the Public Protector on the 2nd of April, wrote to the President on the 8th of April, laid charges on the 23rd of April, laid another ethics complaint on the 27th of April, wrote to the Public Service Commission, PSC on the 28th of April, and wrote to the President twice in May again.

It is a great day for South Africa when political parties, portfolio committee, the media, a special shout out to Rebecca Davis from the Daily Maverick and whistleblowers come together and work for what is right. This is not a win for an individual. It is a win for the most vulnerable people in South Africa.

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The Department of Social Development is one of the most critical departments in government because it serves the most vulnerable in our society. Yet, when one examines the department's 2026-27 annual performance plan and budget, it is clear that there is a disconnect between budget, priorities and outcomes.

The annual performance plan, APP itself reflected poor planning, weak quality control with inconsistencies, poor drafting and glaring omissions. Unfortunately, it mirrors the current state of the department.

The department's budget sits at R302,4 billion, with R284,7 billion transferred to SA Social Security Agency, Sassa. Yet, despite these vast resources, many of the department's targets are shockingly weak. For example, Programme 1 receives R462,8 million, yet key targets include only four oversight visits, monitoring in five districts, and integrating one entity onto a digital platform. South Africans deserve to ask; how can such enormous budgets justify such limited outcomes?

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Programme 3 raises equally serious concerns, Minister. The Basic Income Support policy process initiated in 2022 is only expected to reach Cabinet now and be gazetted in 2028-29, a seven-year timeline for a single policy.

We see the same delays with the Children's Amendment Bill. A department responsible for legislation, norms, and standards cannot spend years producing policy while communities wait for intervention. The department's work on gender-based violence and femicide is equally disappointing. Government repeatedly claims that gender-based violence, GBV, is a national priority, yet this urgency is nowhere to be found in this APP and budget.

Acting Minister, you spoke about the GBV command centre. It's not even in the APP. Only four educational sessions are statutory rape and four GBV shelters for an entire year is wholly inadequate. We cannot claim to tackle gender-based violence and femicide, GBVF, take it seriously while investing so little in the fight.

The department's information, communication and technology, ICT system is outdated. With no meaningful strategy to

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modernise operations, as Sassa moves towards biometric verification, the Department of Social Development risks falling even further behind acting director general, DG. Better data systems and tracking mechanisms are essential to protecting vulnerable people.

The SA Social Security Agency also remains a major concern chief executive officer, CEO. Verification systems are necessary, but they cannot come at the cost of excluding lawful beneficiaries. Elderly people cannot continue standing in queues from 4am in the morning, particularly during winter, only to leave without assistance.

Hon members, the Department of Social Development needs urgent reform. The department has the power to restore dignity, protect lives, and create opportunity. But this can only happen through stronger leadership, real accountability, and renewed commitment to service delivery.

The acting Minister has her work cut out for her. Taking over a department in dire straits will require dedication, courage and difficult decisions, particularly around disciplinary action stemming from the PSC findings and the forensic report.

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All of those who are guilty of wrongdoings, including the former Minister's special advisor, must be held accountable.

This department needs compassionate leadership with a genuine commitment to changing lives. The acting Minister and the acting DG - everybody is acting, must work closely to rebuild a department that serves people effectively. And we will work with you, provided they act with integrity and keep the most vulnerable at every single decision that you make.

I thank you.

*Sepedi:*

Mna K S RAMAILA: Mohl Modulasetulo, Tona ya Motšwa-o-swere, Motlatšatona wa Tlhabollo ya Leago, maloko ao a hlomphegago, bašomi ba mothaladi wa pele, MaAfrika Borwa kamoka ...

*English:*

... I rise on behalf of the ANC to support Budget Vote 19: Social Development, for the 2026-27 financial year. As the ANC, we are saying people first, economic freedom now and no surrender. The centrality of this Budget Vote is that the Department of Social Development strives to move beyond

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protecting the vulnerable, but to empower them to become active participants in building sustainable livelihoods. It enables millions of South Africans to create an enabling environment to chart the future they envisage. But a lot is still demanded to uplift many of our country's citizens.

Former President Thabo Mbeki concisely articulated that work that lies on our shoulders when he said, and I quote, "Freedom is incomplete if it does not improve the material conditions of our people." These words speak directly to the responsibility before us today, which this Budget Vote clearly understands the clarion call to eradicate poverty. Through the social policy and integrated service delivery programmes, R1,2 billion is allocated over a Medium-Term Expenditure Framework, MTEF, to create 283 518 work opportunities in the social sector.

*Sepedi:*

Bouto ye ya ditekanyetšo e bohlokwa kudu go thuša mekgatlo yeo e sego ya mmušo yeo e thušago mmušo e sa patelwe bjalo ka mokgatlo yeo e sego ya mmušo - diNGO, le mekgatlo ya baagi ya setšhaba [civil society organisations.]

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*English:*

... particularly children, the elderly and victims of gender-based violence, GBV, and femicide, the seriousness of the social challenges is robustly tackled by this Budget Vote as it makes an increased allocation within a maximum of 4,7% to this regard. In addition, it illustrates a commitment to enhance the registration and appeals process. However, registration without sustainable funding becomes bureaucracy without impact, and delayed transfers to nonprofit organisations, NPOs, often translate directly into closed shelters, unemployed social workers, and abandoned communication.

Equally important, our focus as a nation must not be narrowly confined to grants, but rather on strengthening the institutions and systems that restore dignity and build lasting opportunity, particularly through nonprofit organisations, civil society organisations, social development infrastructure, child protection services, GBVF interventions, and sustainable livelihoods programmes. Hon members and fellow South Africans, a social worker cannot protect a child without a functioning place of safety. A victim of abuse cannot heal without shelter. Foster care systems cannot succeed without

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capacitated child protection centres. Community development cannot thrive without service points close to the people.

We commend the department for allocating R271,5 million over the medium term in the social crime prevention and victim empowerment, precisely because women and children continue to suffer violence inside homes, schools, and communities. The Budget Vote responds to the victim's pride because it understands that survivors need more than sympathy; they need shelters, psychological support, legal pathways, and economic independence.

However, given the scourge of GBV and hundreds of abused children, the amount must be increased to meet the demand. In essence, infrastructure in Social Development is not a luxury, but it is the foundation of protection and empowerment.

President Ramaphosa perfectly directed us on what is to be done when he said and I quote, "Empowering women financially gives them greater control over their lives." The department, with various stakeholders, must forge ahead with its endeavours to empower women.



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Equally, the Children's Act gives effect to the constitutional rights of children and places a duty upon the state to ensure their care and protection. Yet, we continue to face foster care backlogs, delayed court processes, and an overstretched child protection system. This Budget Vote resolves some of the structural challenges as it prioritises finalising the Children's Amendment Bill and strengthening parenting programmes and psychological services, with R259,8 billion allocated to children subprogrammes over MTEF period. This Budget Vote is critical in asserting that our children in foster care are not statistics, but a measure of whether our democracy truly protects the vulnerable. We continue to build sustainable foster care and strengthen adoption services.

As the ANC postulates that physical service points and satellites, whether using local schools or traditional tribal authorities, facilities must be expanded to bring services to those who might be faced with connectivity challenges. We must leave no qualifying potential beneficiary behind. We maintain that digital justice is social justice. Some of the opposing parties act as though technology is a foreign concept of SA Social Security Agency, Sassa. They are late for the party. We have actively wiped out over 34 000 fraudulent grants. The ANC

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is implementing real-world compliance and digital solutions, while some of you in your opposition benches are still writing basic ideas on your flyers.

This Budget Vote must be seen not simply as expenditure but as an investment in human dignity. The struggle against poverty is not won by income support alone. It is won when people gain the means to stand independently, contribute meaningfully, and live with dignity, and that is the true centre of economic opportunity. This Budget Vote's commitment is reverberated by the words of Gandhi, and I quote, "Poverty is the worst form of violence."

As we were committed to fighting oppression, we are more committed to unleashing an unrelenting war against poverty. I want the people of South Africa to understand that some will come and stand here, speak left, but walk ultra-right. Some will come and stand here religiously, and face salaries every month, but come here not to support the budget, meaning you should not end the social grants that you deserve. As you meet them out there, ask them, "Who is fooling who?" I thank you.

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The ACTING MINISTER OF SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT (Ms L S Chikunga):  
Hon House Chairperson, let me begin by thanking hon members for their contributions to this debate. I have listened carefully to the issues raised, the concerns expressed, and proposals made. But of course, I also listened to politics. Allow me to also look forward to working with MECs that are responsible for Social Development from all nine provinces.

Also, I wish to express my appreciation to former Minister Sisisi Tolashe for the work she has done in stabilising the department as well as stabilising its entities. It is true hon Sokanyile and hon Ramaila that social grants are a bridge to a brighter future, empowering our people, particularly young ones to participate actively in the economy.

Hon Mtshweni, what you did not tell us is the fact that with the cash pay points, there were so many cash heist that happened in South Africa. Come from Elukwatini, it was known that the money is going to come, there will be criminals, there will be cash heists. So that was the problem about this. But also, everybody, the criminals knew that old woman is having cash in her purse. And therefore, they were actually robbing them. That is the problem. They will break into their

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houses and take money because they will be knowing for sure that there is money. And that is why that system, even if it was benefiting Small, Medium, and Micro Enterprises, SMMEs, but it was not benefiting the SA Social Security Agency, Sassa, it was not benefiting the beneficiaries. It was also not benefiting the taxpayers. That is the problem about it.

But also, it is true, hon Machi, it is not true that technology is a barrier. As a matter of fact, we are using both technologies, but also Sassa offices. So those who cannot use technology, they still go to Sassa offices, to kiosk, to apply, and also to check whatever that they want to check. It can actually be done as quickly as all that.

I did not understand, hon Mtshweni, is whether you are saying we must do away with grants because we cannot, as a matter of fact. We do have problems of unemployment. We have said this repeatedly; young people are unemployed. However, we are saying this is assisting them to be able, I mean, hon member said some, they put together money and they started a bakery. That is what we are looking forward to as our hon members and as we make these contributions.

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Coming to hon James, I have not seen your message, ma'am. And I do request that you resend it to my WhatsApp. Resend it, please, so that I can check it. I am more than prepared to look into your message. Other members prepared their speeches last week, and they could not change their speeches to date. So irrelevant in some of the aspects of their speeches, they were still prepared to deliver them as they are. There have been changes now and you should have changed your speeches, and it would have been as easy as all that.

Hon Nontenja, the Child Support Grant does cover all eligible children, including those in the zero-to-two age cohort. So, it does cover them. On the issue of long queues during COVID-19, but of course now COVID-19 is over and therefore people can still apply, those who did not apply at the time, maybe because of long queues. So, the application is still opened for them. I really want to thank you again as I have said, I hope to be working together with the members, work together with the members and everybody that is here. Social Grant is to empower people. Let us go out and vote and vote for the ANC. I thank you. [Time expired.]

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The HOUSE CHAIRPERSON (Mr W Horn): Order hon members. Hon members, the day is not yet done. You are reminded that at 16h45 today, two further budget debates will take place. Vote No 31, Employment and Labour. That debate will take place in this Chamber, the Goodhope Chamber. Whilst in M46, there are three budgets that will be debated simultaneously. That is No 28, Police, No 24, the Independent Police Investigative Directorate, and No 21, the Civilian Secretariat for the Police. Your presence at either of those will be highly appreciated.

Debate concluded.

The mini plenary session rose at 15:49.